CRIME INVESTIGATION ANALYSIS IN INDIA

A Comprehensive Statistical Study Using NCRB Crime in India 2019 — Table 17A

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Data Source	Reference Year
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Abstract

Every year, India's police force works through a staggering volume of cases — crimes registered, investigated, sent to court, or quietly closed. But what does that process actually look like from start to finish? How many cases are successfully brought to court? How many are closed because the accused was never found? And how does the system perform on the most serious crimes compared to everyday offences?

This report answers those questions with evidence drawn directly from the National Crime Records Bureau's (NCRB) Crime in India 2019 publication — specifically Table 17A, which traces the complete journey of a cognizable IPC case from first registration to final disposal. The dataset covers over 44 lakh cases across 55 major crime categories, making it one of the most comprehensive administrative crime statistics datasets in the world.

The findings are sobering but not hopeless. India's overall Charge-Sheeting Rate of 67.2% is respectable by international standards — but beneath that average lie sharp inequalities. Property crimes are prosecuted at barely 28.5%. Over seven lakh crimes were officially acknowledged as real but went uncharged because evidence could not be gathered. More than 20,000 murder investigations remained open at year's end. At

the same time, the system shows genuine strengths: traffic and public order offences are prosecuted at near-perfect rates, and crimes against women are increasingly reaching the chargesheet stage.

Keywords: NCRB, Crime in India 2019, Charge-Sheeting Rate, IPC Crimes, Police Investigation, Case Pendency, Descriptive Statistics, Criminal Justice, India

1. Introduction

Public conversations about crime in India tend to focus on headline cases. What rarely gets attention is the administrative machinery that quietly handles millions of cases every year — the investigation pipeline that begins the moment an FIR is filed and ends, or sometimes fails to end, when a case is chargesheeted, closed, or carried into the next year's backlog.

The National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB), established in 1986 under the Ministry of Home Affairs and publishing crime statistics since 1953, fills this gap. Unlike media reporting which amplifies exceptional cases, NCRB data captures patterns — the structural reasons why certain crimes are rarely prosecuted, why certain investigations never close, and where the system works quietly well.

Table 17A of CII 2019 is particularly revealing. It maps the entire investigative lifecycle: inherited cases, fresh reports, chargesheets, final reports (and crucially why they were filed), and year-end pending counts. Two derived metrics anchor this analysis: the Charge-Sheeting Rate (CSR), which measures prosecution efficiency, and Pendency Percentage, which measures unresolved accumulation. Together, they provide a diagnostic picture of the criminal justice system that raw crime counts cannot offer.

2. Dataset and Methodology

2.1 Source Data

All data is drawn from NCRB Crime in India 2019 — Statistics Volume I, Table 17A: "Cognizable IPC Crimes — Cases Reported, Chargesheeted and Disposal by Police during 2019." The table covers the entire country at All-India aggregate level across 143 data rows, 55 primary crime heads and their sub-categories, with 24 columns tracking every stage of the investigation lifecycle.

2.2 Key Variables Tracked

The 24 columns tell the complete story of a case. On the intake side: cases pending from the previous year, fresh cases reported during 2019, and cases reopened for re-investigation. On the resolution side: cases transferred, withdrawn by government, or closed via five categories of Final Report (false, civil dispute, true but insufficient evidence, non-cognizable, abated). The table also records chargesheets filed, year-end pending totals, calculated CSR, and Pendency Percentage.

2.3 Analytical Framework

This study uses descriptive and comparative analysis structured across five phases: (1) Volume Analysis — ranking crime heads by reported cases; (2) Category Summary — comparing major IPC groupings on CSR and pendency; (3) CSR Analysis — identifying best and worst performers and exploring structural causes; (4) Pendency Analysis — examining which cases never close and why; (5) Final Report Decomposition — understanding why over 10 lakh cases were closed without prosecution. All computed values (percentage shares) are derived from official NCRB raw counts.

SCOPE AND LIMITATIONS

This table covers IPC offences only — crimes under Special and Local Laws are reported separately. All figures are All-India aggregates; state-level variation is not visible. The hierarchical table structure means all computations in this study use only "Total" and "Grand Total" rows to avoid double-counting.

3. The National Picture: Scale and Structure

3.1 India's Investigation Pipeline at a Glance

In 2019, India's police were managing a combined total of 44,70,678 IPC cases. Of these, 12,42,827 cases (27.8%) were not new — they were unresolved cases carried forward from previous years. This inherited backlog means that even before a single new crime was reported in 2019, officers across the country were already working through over 12 lakh old files.

By year-end, the system closed 31,60,323 cases — a significant achievement, but not enough to clear the workload. A further 13,07,738 cases remained open, producing a year-end Pendency Percentage of 29.3%. Almost three in every ten cases active in 2019 were still unresolved when the year ended. This is a structural pattern, not an anomaly,

reflecting a system that consistently processes fewer cases than it receives.

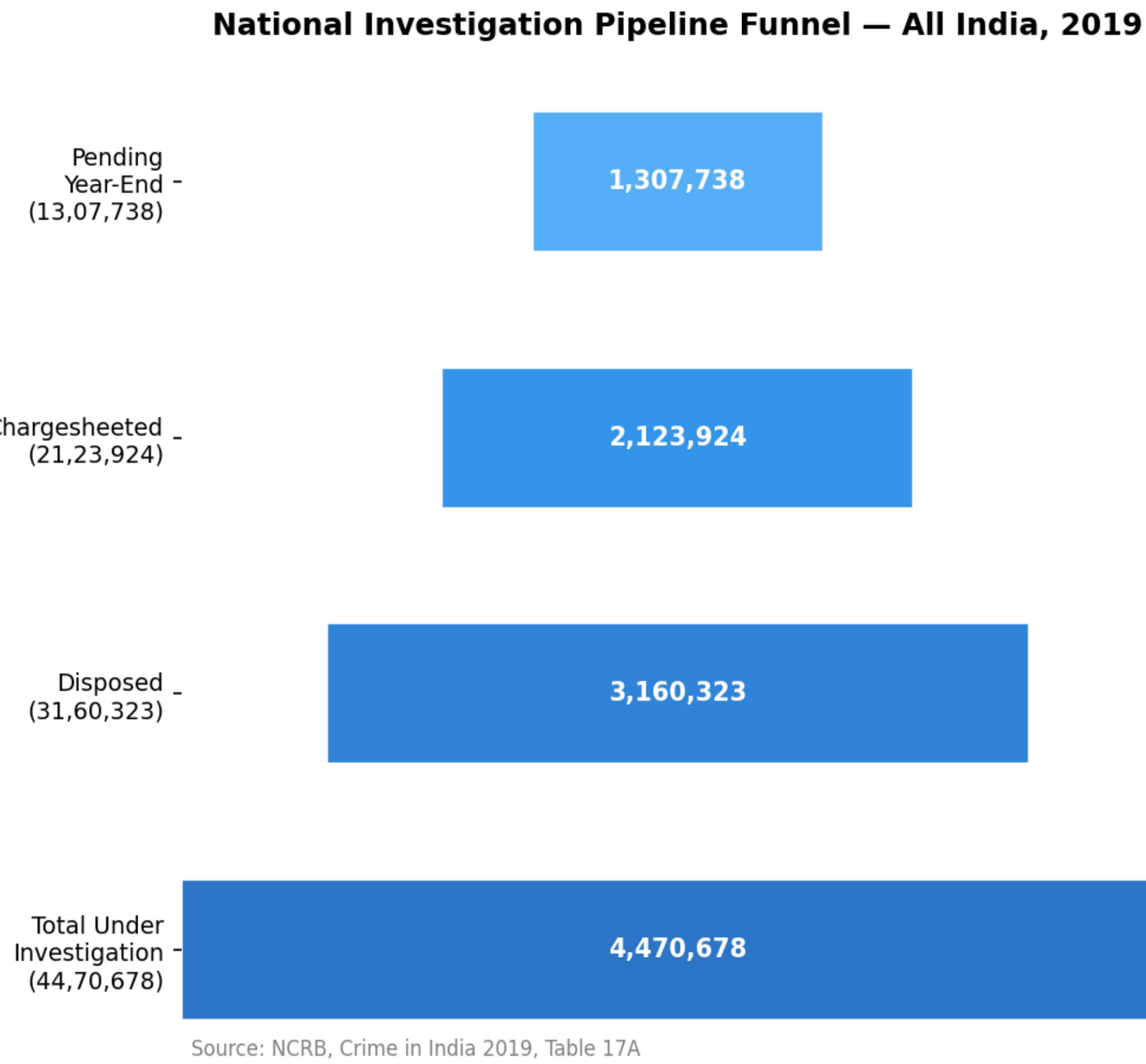


Figure 1: National Investigation Pipeline Funnel — All India, 2019 | Source: NCRB, Crime in India 2019, Table 17A

3.2 Performance by Major IPC Category

Disaggregating the national picture by crime category reveals dramatic variation in both prosecution efficiency and case resolution. The seven major groupings show CSRs ranging from 28.5% to 90.0% and pendency from 21.4% to 80.7%.

Crime Category	Total Under Inv.	Prev. Yr Pending	Reported 2019	CSR (%)	Pendency (%)
Offences Against Human Body	14,43,596	3,92,348	10,50,945	80.1%	29.4%
Offences Against Property	12,00,676	3,44,631	8,54,618	28.5%	28.7%
Miscellaneous IPC Crimes	10,70,805	2,10,518	8,60,209	90.0%	21.4%
Other IPC Crimes	3,60,956	1,09,363	2,51,455	71.8%	31.0%
Docs. & Property Marks	2,87,768	1,42,681	1,44,949	53.8%	54.8%
Offences Against Public Tranquillity	1,06,050	42,626	63,359	87.0%	36.8%

Crime Category	Total Under Inv.	Prev. Yr Pending	Reported 2019	CSR (%)	Pendency (%)
Offences Against the State	827	660	166	53.1%	80.7%
GRAND TOTAL	44,70,678	12,42,827	32,25,701	67.2%	29.3%

Table 1: Crime Investigation Pipeline by Major IPC Category — All India, 2019 | Source: NCRB CII 2019, Table 17A

Miscellaneous IPC Crimes achieves a CSR of 90.0% with the lowest pendency at 21.4% — largely offences where the accused is identifiable on the spot. Offences Against Property show the opposite: a CSR of 28.5%, meaning seven in ten disposed property cases ended without prosecution. Offences Against the State — sedition and related charges — show 80.7% pendency, reflecting lengthy legal battles and political complexity.

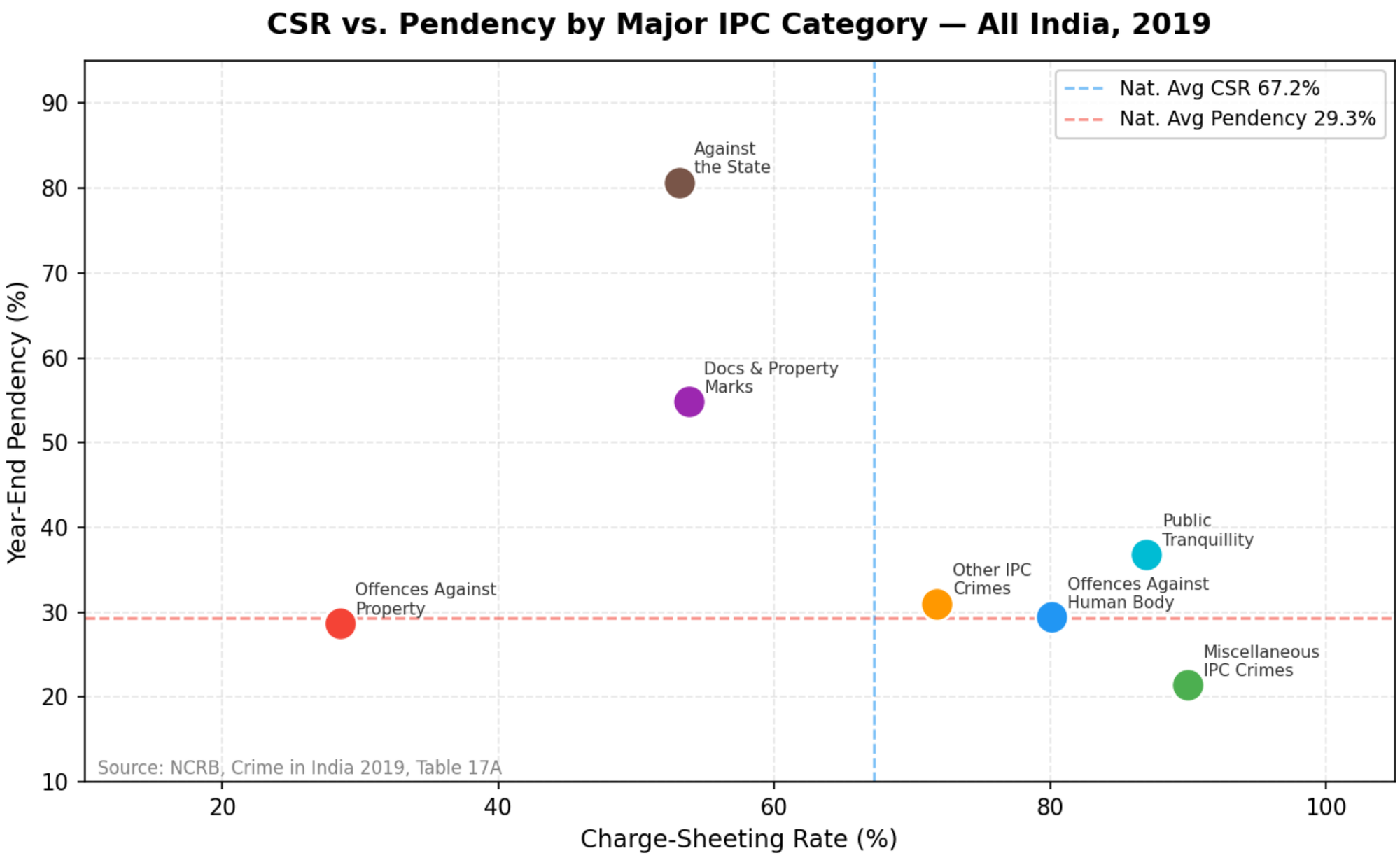


Figure 2: CSR vs. Pendency by Major IPC Category — All India, 2019 | Source: NCRB CII 2019, Table 17A

4. Volume Analysis: Where the System Faces Greatest Strain

Ranking individual crime heads by reported case volume reveals which offences place the greatest demands on the investigation system — and how well the system responds to that pressure.

Crime Head	Cases Reported	Total Under Inv.	CSR (%)	Pendency (%)
Theft (all forms)	6,75,916	9,10,940	22.1%	25.2%
Hurt (all forms)	5,45,061	7,02,640	87.7%	24.9%
Rash Driving on Public Way	4,17,024	5,15,025	91.3%	20.3%
Causing Death by Negligence	1,44,842	1,92,382	76.8%	27.1%
Cruelty by Husband/Relatives	1,25,298	1,73,112	81.5%	31.4%
Criminal Intimidation	1,01,422	1,18,045	90.8%	16.4%
Burglary (all forms)	1,00,897	1,55,743	38.8%	36.6%
Kidnapping & Abduction	1,05,037	1,73,245	37.3%	41.1%
Assault on Women (total)	88,367	1,22,190	84.3%	28.7%
Murder (incl. attempts)	28,918	48,553	85.3%	43.1%

Table 2: Top 10 Crime Heads by Cases Reported — All India, 2019 | Source: NCRB CII 2019, Table 17A

Theft dominates the volume rankings with 6,75,916 new cases — nearly 21% of all IPC registrations. Yet its CSR of 22.1% means fewer than one in four resolved theft cases resulted in a chargesheet. The contrast with Rash Driving (CSR 91.3%, pendency 20.3%) captures the structural divide perfectly: traffic offences are easily resolved because the accused is present at the scene; theft investigations begin after the fact, with an anonymous perpetrator and minimal traceable evidence.

Murder presents the most sobering figure. With 48,553 cases under investigation and a 43.1% pendency, over 20,000 murder cases were still open at year-end. For the gravest of all offences, this accumulated backlog represents a serious failure of the justice system's most fundamental obligation.

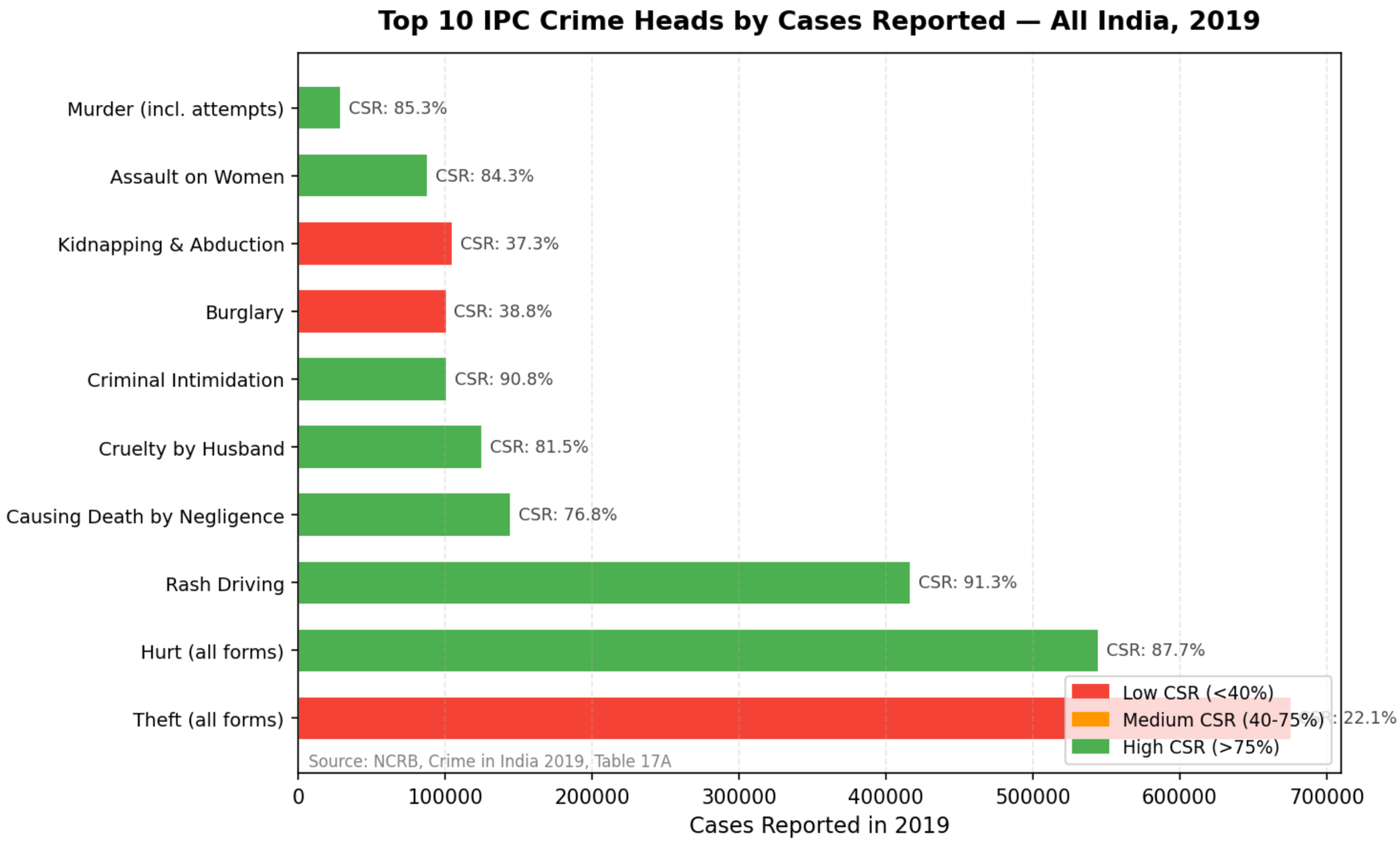


Figure 3: Top 10 Crime Heads by Cases Reported (Red=CSR<40%, Orange=40–75%, Green>75%) | Source: NCRB CII 2019, Table 17A

5. Charge-Sheeting Rate: The Prosecution Divide

The Charge-Sheeting Rate varies more widely across crime categories than any other metric in the dataset. At one extreme, certain offences achieve near-perfect CSRs; at the other, the majority of disposed cases end in final reports rather than prosecution. The range — from below 22% to above 99% — reveals structural, not incidental, differences.

Crime Head	Cases Reported	CSR (%)	Pendency (%)	Category
— HIGHEST CSR —				
Obstruction on Public Way	93,343	99.8%	6.1%	Public Order
Affray	7,148	99.7%	18.9%	Public Order
Making Preparation for Dacoity	3,338	98.0%	32.3%	Property/Gang Crime
Rash Driving — Simple	1,44,059	96.9%	7.9%	Traffic Offence
Obscene Acts at Public Places	24,708	96.1%	14.9%	Misc. IPC
— LOWEST CSR —				
Auto Theft	18,264	21.6%	26.2%	Property Crime
Theft (General)	6,75,916	22.1%	25.2%	Property Crime
Missing Children (Kidnapped cat.)	74,969	20.4%	44.8%	Persons Crime

Crime Head	Cases Reported	CSR (%)	Pendency (%)	Category
Burglary by Day	30,026	33.5%	34.1%	Property Crime
Kidnapping to Compel Marriage	32,260	46.9%	40.4%	Persons Crime

Table 3: Highest and Lowest Charge-Sheeting Rates by Crime Head — All India, 2019 | Source: NCRB CII 2019, Table 17A

High-CSR offences share a common structural feature: they occur in public, the accused is present and identifiable, and the evidence required is immediate and simple. Obstruction on a public road, affray in a public space, rash driving on a highway — in each case, police arrive to find both a crime and an offender. Four in five disposed cases become chargesheets almost automatically.

Property crimes occupy the opposite extreme. In roughly four of every five disposed theft or auto theft cases, no chargesheet was filed. The central problem is anonymous criminality: the offender acts without being identified and leaves minimal forensic trace. This is not a failure of police effort — it is a failure of forensic and investigative infrastructure, and addressing it requires systemic investment, not just operational change.

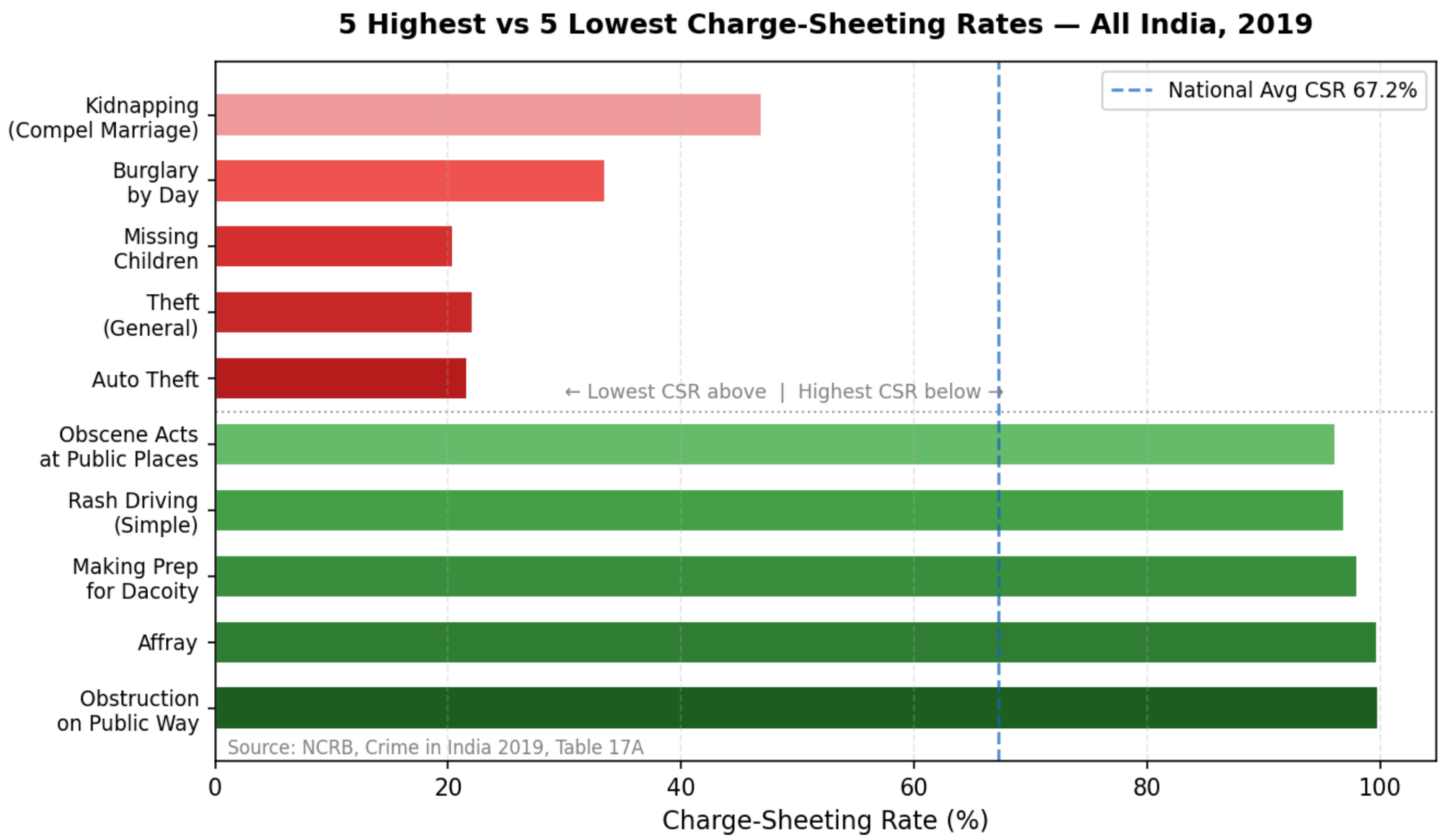


Figure 4: 5 Highest vs 5 Lowest CSR Crime Heads — National Average 67.2% | Source: NCRB CII 2019, Table 17A

6. Pendency Analysis: Cases That Never Close

While CSR measures the quality of outcomes when cases resolve, Pendency Percentage reveals a different kind of failure: cases that simply accumulate without resolution. Some categories show pendency so extreme that they describe a system structurally incapable of handling specific investigation types.

Crime Head	Cases Reported	Total Under Inv.	CSR (%)	Pendency (%)
— HIGHEST PENDENCY —				
Counterfeit Coin	20	791	63.2%	97.6%
Buying of Minors for Prostitution	8	40	50.0%	85.0%
Offences Against the State	166	827	53.1%	80.7%
Selling of Minors for Prostitution	24	148	71.4%	71.6%
Counterfeit Currency & Bank Notes	1,010	3,543	66.0%	58.2%
— LOWEST PENDENCY —				
Obstruction on Public Way	93,343	96,432	99.8%	6.1%
Rash Driving — Simple	1,44,059	1,51,523	96.9%	7.9%
Obscene Acts at Public Places	24,708	27,419	96.1%	14.9%
Criminal Intimidation	1,01,422	1,18,045	90.8%	16.4%
Affray	7,148	7,798	99.7%	18.9%

Table 4: Highest and Lowest Pendency Percentages by Crime Head — All India, 2019 | Source: NCRB CII 2019, Table 17A

Counterfeit Coin cases are essentially a museum exhibit of stalled investigations. Of 791 cases under investigation in 2019, only 20 were freshly registered; the remaining 771 were inherited from previous years. With a pendency rate of 97.6%, virtually none resolved. These investigations require numismatic expertise, organised crime intelligence, and often international cooperation — capacities simply unavailable in the standard police apparatus.

Offences Against the State — primarily sedition cases under Section 124A IPC — show 80.7% pendency for a different reason: legal complexity, frequent High Court and Supreme Court stay orders, and political sensitivity. Cases sub judice cannot conclude while in legal contest. Meanwhile, child exploitation offences stagnate for structural capacity reasons, with their small absolute numbers masking almost certain severe under-reporting.

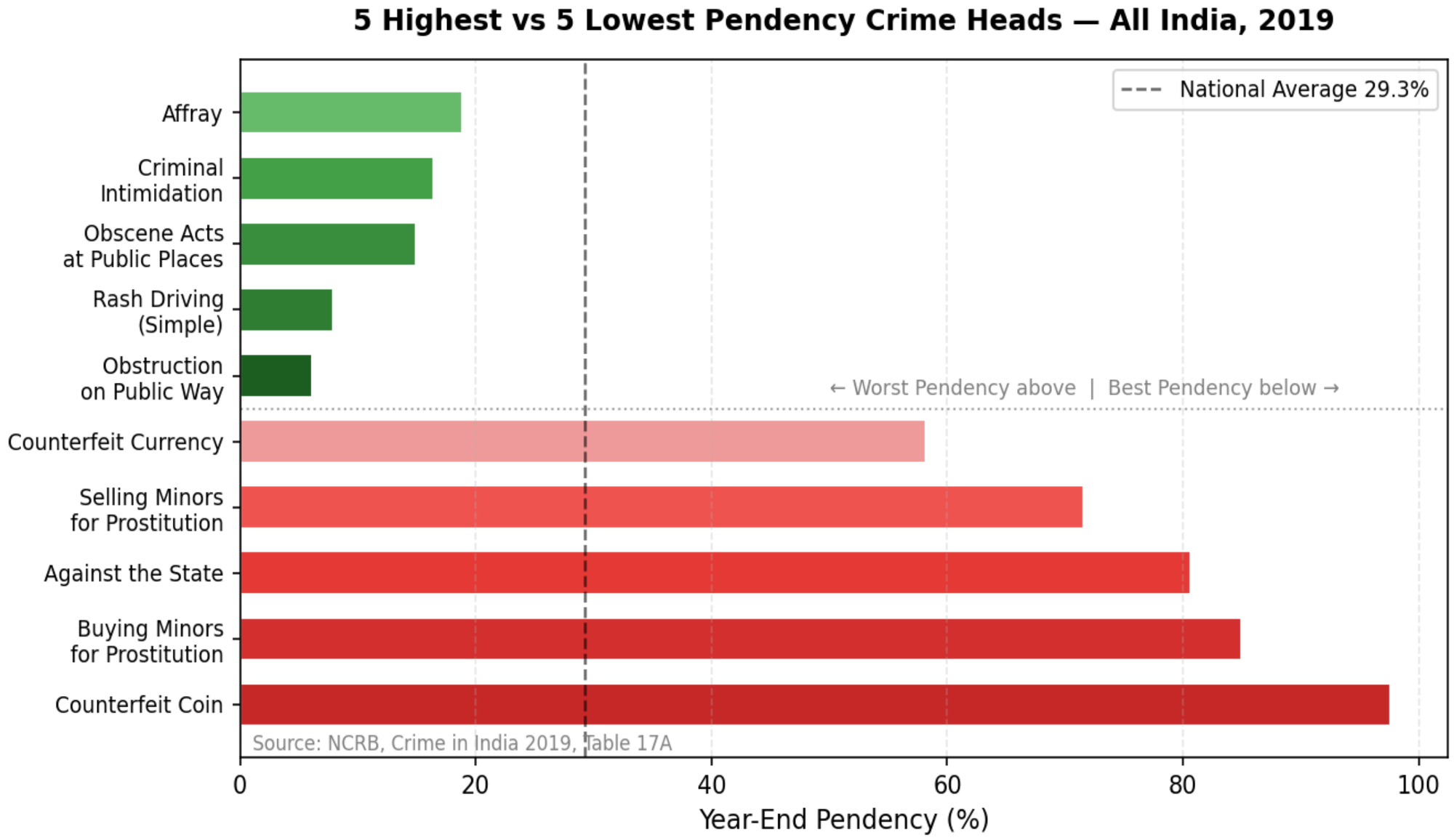


Figure 5: 5 Highest vs 5 Lowest Pendency Crime Heads — National Average 29.3% | Source: NCRB CII 2019, Table 17A

7. Why Cases Close Without Prosecution

Of the 31,60,323 cases disposed in 2019, as many as 10,32,519 — nearly one in three — were closed without a chargesheet. These closures are recorded through "Final Reports" — official police decisions that a case cannot proceed to prosecution. Understanding why these reports are filed is the most diagnostically important analysis this dataset allows.

Category of Final Report	Number of Cases	Share of Total FRs (%)
Non-Cognizable (FR-NC)	11,477	1.11%
Final Report — False	1,21,745	11.79%
Mistake of Fact / Law / Civil Dispute	1,51,069	14.63%
True but Insufficient Evidence / Untraced / No Clue	7,33,303	71.02%
Abated During Investigation	14,925	1.45%
TOTAL FINAL REPORTS	10,32,519	100.00%

Table 5: Composition of Final Reports Filed by Police — All India, 2019 | Source: NCRB CII 2019, Table 17A

The figure that demands attention is 7,33,303 — cases closed as "True but Insufficient Evidence / Untraced / No Clue." At 71.02% of all final reports, this dwarfs every other closure reason. The word "True" here is not incidental — in all these cases, police formally acknowledge that a real crime occurred. The system did not close these cases because they were fabricated or civil disputes. It closed them because it could not find

the perpetrator or gather enough evidence to support prosecution.

To put that in human terms: over seven lakh crime victims in 2019 received official confirmation that yes, a crime was committed against them — and no, the system cannot hold anyone accountable. Each of those 700,000+ cases represents a potential emboldening of offenders who escaped the system, and a possible deterrent against future victims reporting at all. The downstream effects on public trust and deterrence are significant.

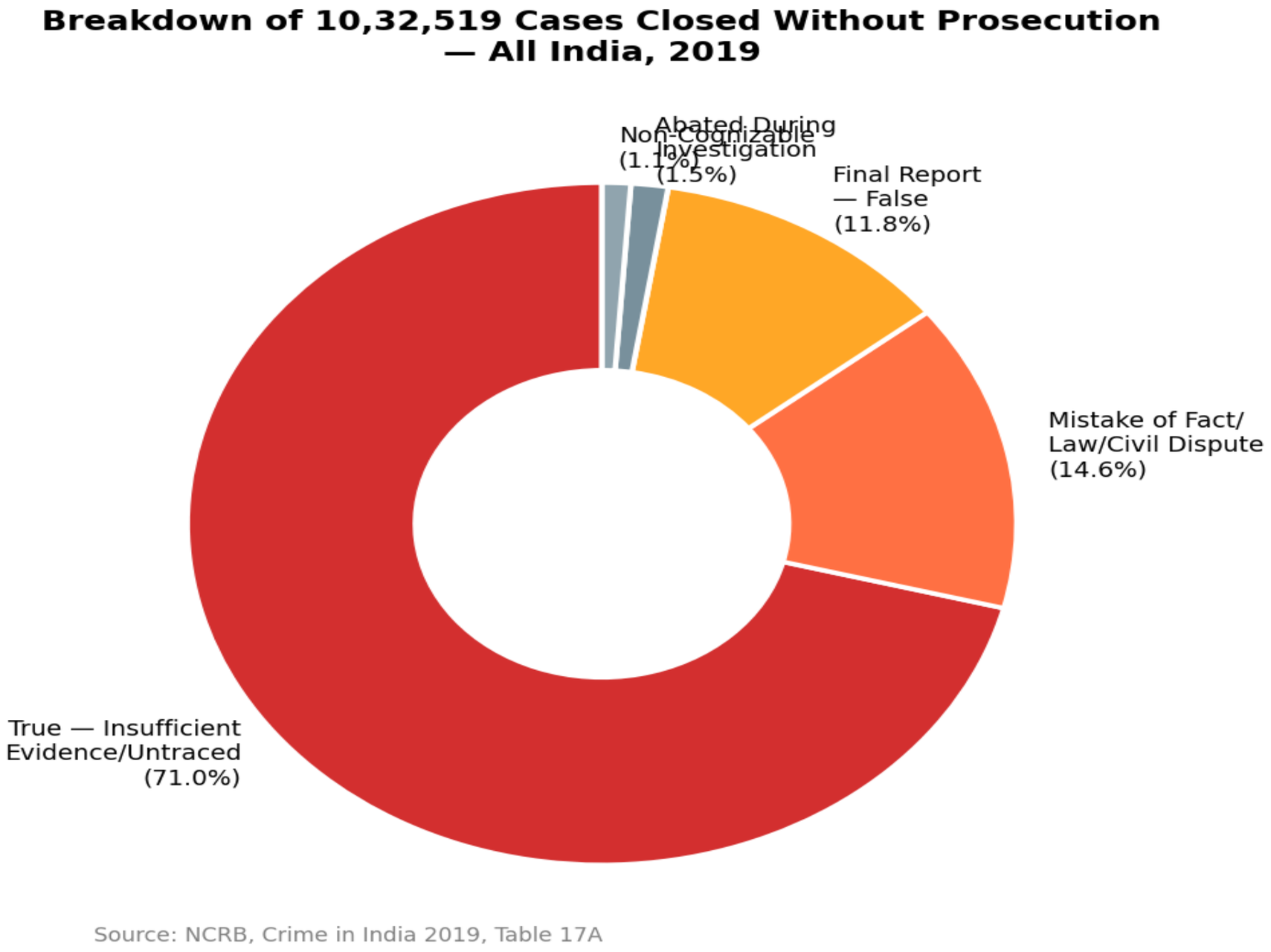


Figure 6: Breakdown of 10,32,519 Cases Closed Without Prosecution — All India, 2019 | Source: NCRB CII 2019, Table 17A

7.1 Full Disposition Profile by Category

The chart below shows the full disposition profile for each major IPC category — the proportional split between chargesheeted, closed via final report, and still pending at year-end. The contrast between the Property category and all others is immediately apparent.

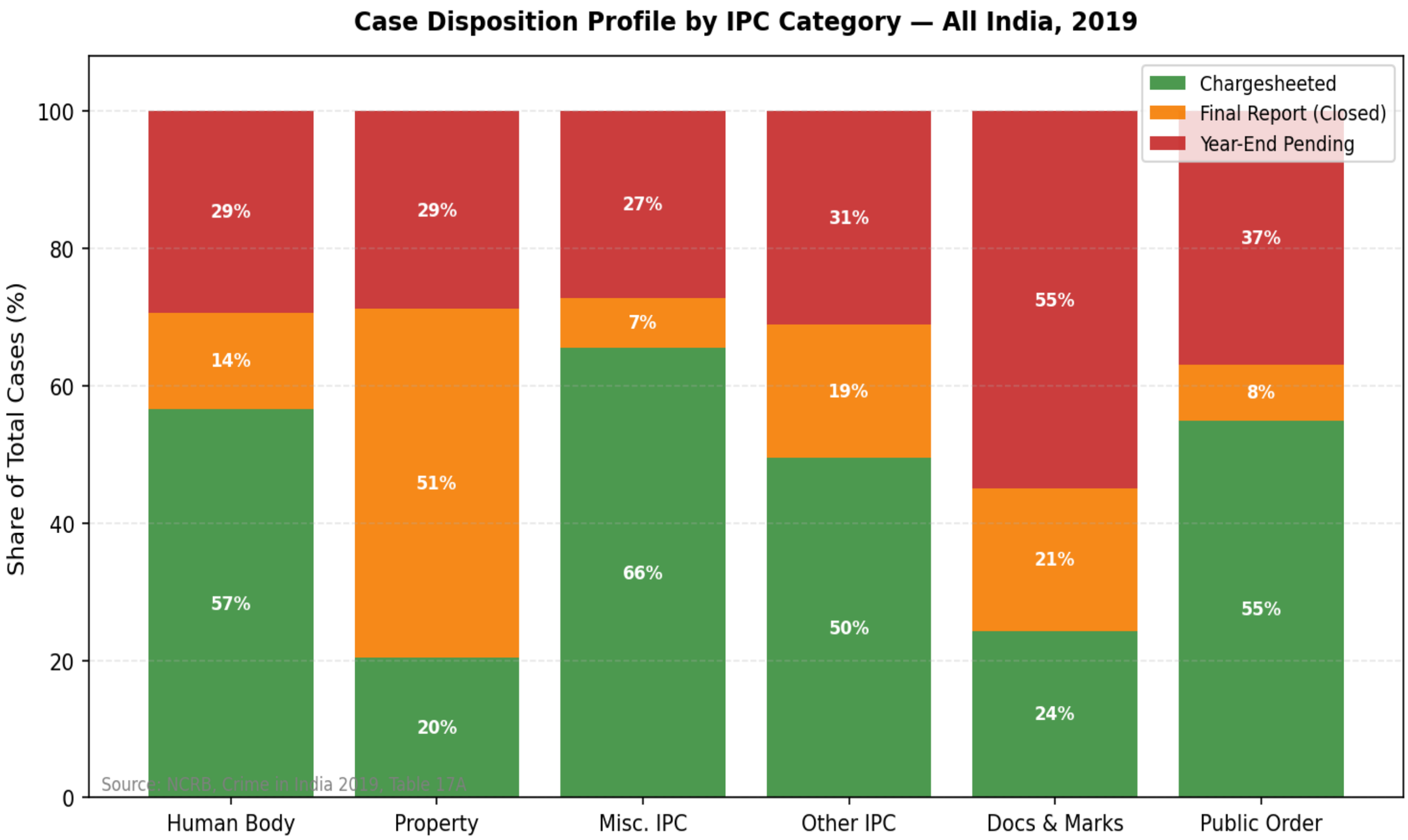


Figure 7: Case Disposition Profile by IPC Category — All India, 2019 | Source: NCRB CII 2019, Table 17A

Crime Category	Chargesheeted	Final Reports	Total Disposed	CSR (%)
Human Body	8,16,394	2,02,101	10,19,085	80.1%
Property	2,43,950	6,08,752	8,54,869	28.5%
Miscellaneous IPC	7,56,784	83,678	8,40,740	90.0%
Docs. & Property Marks	69,781	59,341	1,29,771	53.8%
Public Tranquillity	58,229	8,646	66,900	87.0%
Other IPC Crimes	1,78,701	69,930	2,48,798	71.8%
GRAND TOTAL	21,23,924	10,32,519	31,60,323	67.2%

Table 6: Chargesheeted vs. Final Reports by Category — All India, 2019 | Source: NCRB CII 2019, Table 17A

The Property category's profile is stark: of 8,54,869 disposed property cases, 6,08,752 — over 71% — were closed without prosecution. Compared to Miscellaneous IPC where 90% of disposals became chargesheets, this reveals not merely statistical differences but

fundamentally different investigative realities driven by the nature of the offences themselves.

8. Crimes Against Women and Children

Given the Criminal Law (Amendment) Act, 2013, the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, 2012 (POCSO), and multiple Supreme Court directives on gender-based violence, these categories deserve analysis separate from the broader dataset. The question is whether legislative intent has translated into investigative outcomes on the ground.

Crime Head	Reported 2019	Total Under Inv.	CSR (%)	Pendency (%)	Status
Dowry Deaths	7,115	10,411	90.3%	33.1%	Strong
Stalking	8,890	12,901	87.2%	34.9%	Good
Assault on Women (total)	88,367	1,22,190	84.3%	28.7%	Good
Rape	32,033	45,536	81.5%	32.9%	Moderate
Cruelty by Husband/Relatives	1,25,298	1,73,112	81.5%	31.4%	Moderate
Human Trafficking	1,334	2,412	86.0%	50.6%	Concern
Attempt to Commit Rape	3,944	5,781	72.7%	30.2%	Moderate
Kidnapping — Compel to Marry	32,260	54,871	46.9%	40.4%	Poor
Selling of Minors for Prostitution	24	148	71.4%	71.6%	Critical
Buying of Minors for Prostitution	8	40	50.0%	85.0%	Critical

Table 7: Investigation Metrics — Crimes Against Women & Children, 2019 | Source: NCRB CII 2019, Table 17A

Cruelty by Husband or Relatives leads on sheer scale: 1,25,298 new cases in a single year — larger than all Burglary cases combined. The 81.5% CSR shows that when these cases reach disposal, prosecution is the norm. But the 31.4% pendency means approximately 54,000 domestic violence investigations were still ongoing at year-end, leaving tens of thousands of survivors in prolonged legal uncertainty.

Rape (32,033 new cases) shows an 81.5% CSR broadly consistent with international benchmarks. However, the 32.9% pendency translates to roughly 14,961 rape cases open at year-end. Each represents a survivor waiting for investigation to conclude, often while managing trauma and the continued presence of an accused in their community. The post-2012 legislative promise of swift justice remains incompletely delivered.

The child exploitation figures are small in absolute terms and alarming in relative terms. Human Trafficking showed 50.6% pendency — half of all active trafficking investigations were unresolved at year-end. For child prostitution offences, pendency reaches 71.6% and 85.0% respectively. These small case counts almost certainly reflect severe under-reporting of crimes that are, by nature, hidden and coercive.

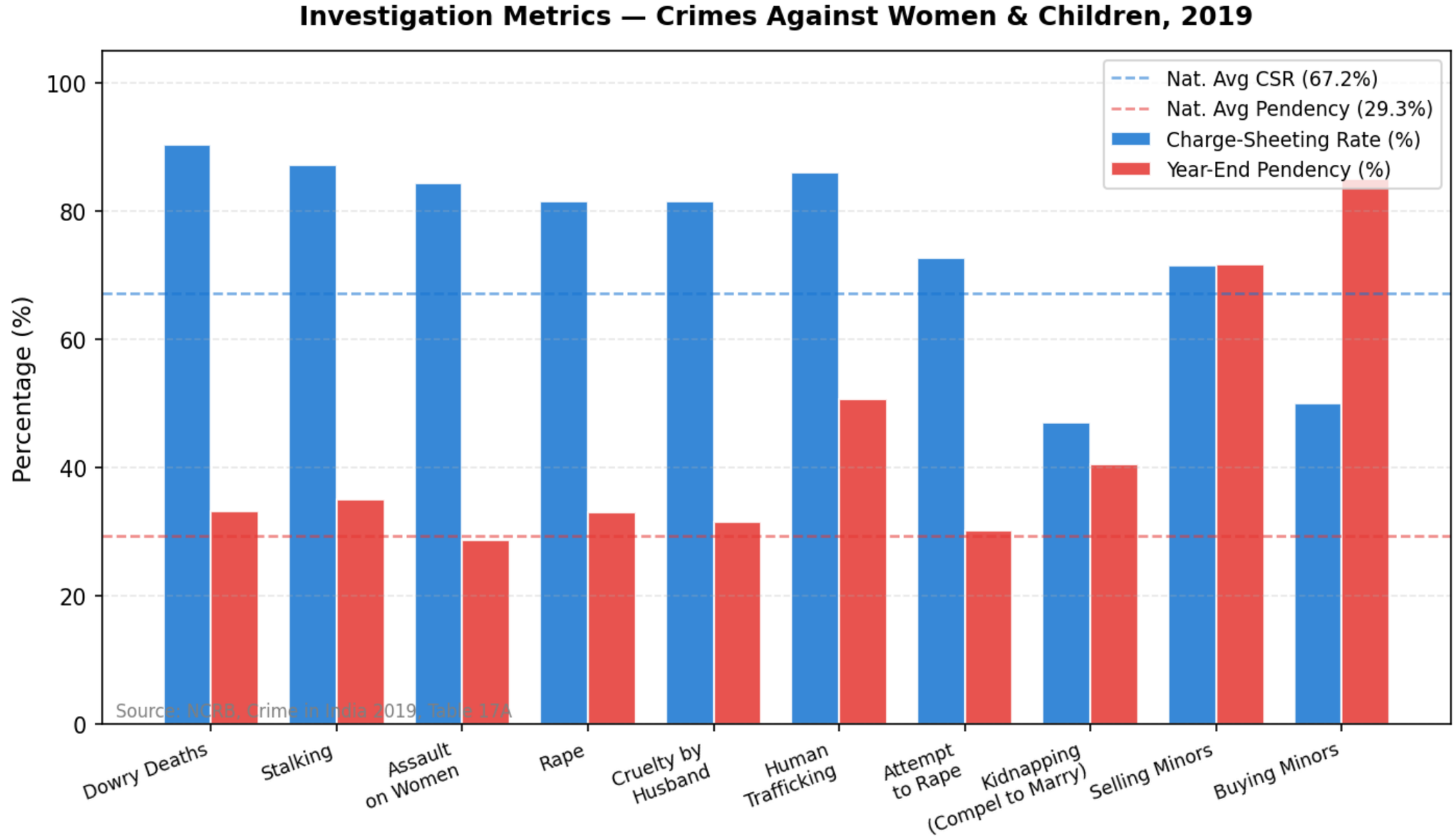


Figure 8: CSR and Pendency — Crimes Against Women & Children (Dashed = National Averages) | Source: NCRB CII 2019, Table 17A

9. Summary of Key Findings

Finding 1 — Scale and Structural Backlog: India managed 44,70,678 IPC cases in 2019, with 27.8% inherited from previous years. The 29.3% year-end pendency means the system ended 2019 with a larger backlog than it started — a compounding structural problem.

Finding 2 — Property Crime Investigation Failure: Theft (CSR 22.1%), Auto Theft (21.6%), and Burglary (38.8%) represent the clearest systemic failure. Most property cases close without prosecution because the accused cannot be identified — a forensic and technological capacity problem, not a motivation problem.

Finding 3 — The Evidence Gap: 71.02% of all final reports — 7,33,303 cases — cite insufficient evidence, untraced accused, or no clue. Police acknowledge these as real crimes. This points to a nationwide deficit in forensic infrastructure, crime scene investigation, and digital investigation tools.

Finding 4 — The On-Scene Prosecution Advantage: Near-perfect CSRs are concentrated among observable, on-scene offences — Obstruction (99.8%), Affray (99.7%), Rash Driving (96.9%). Investigation outcomes are heavily dependent on whether the accused is present and identifiable when police arrive.

Finding 5 — Domestic Violence at Scale: Cruelty by Husband or Relatives (1,25,298 new cases) is the fifth-largest crime category. The 81.5% CSR shows active prosecution, but 31.4% pendency means tens of thousands of survivors remain in legal limbo at any given time.

Finding 6 — Trafficking and Child Exploitation: Human Trafficking (50.6% pendency), Selling of Minors (71.6%), and Buying of Minors (85.0%) are the worst-performing serious person crime categories. Small case numbers almost certainly reflect severe under-reporting of hidden, coercive crimes.

Finding 7 — Murder Backlog: Murder's 43.1% year-end pendency, with over 20,000 cases unresolved, is the most serious operational failure for any high-gravity individual crime. The combination of inherited backlog and annual accumulation creates a compounding crisis in homicide investigation.

Finding 8 — Specialised Cases Stagnate: Offences Against the State (80.7% pendency) and

Counterfeit Coin (97.6%) demonstrate that cases requiring specialised legal or forensic expertise stagnate completely in the standard investigation pipeline.

10. Policy Recommendations

1. Invest in Forensic Infrastructure. Since 71% of non-prosecution closures cite insufficient evidence, expanding CFSL branch facilities, building DNA and fingerprint databases with mandatory matching, installing CCTV in high-crime areas, and creating stolen goods tracking systems is the most direct path to improving CSRs nationally.

2. Create Specialised Property Crime Units. A 22% CSR for theft cannot improve through general policing. Dedicated units with ANPR systems, vehicle tracking technology, organised retail crime intelligence, and real-time liaison with pawn shops and dealers are needed. This mirrors approaches that have worked in comparable international jurisdictions.

3. Strengthen Anti-Trafficking and Child Protection Capacity. The 50– 85% pendency rates in trafficking categories require multi-state jurisdiction, undercover capabilities, and dedicated teams. India's Anti-Human Trafficking Units (AHTUs) under MHA need substantially expanded mandates, resources, and NGO coordination frameworks.

4. Establish Cold Case Review Teams for Murder. A 43.1% murder pendency rate is unacceptable as a steady-state outcome. Dedicated cold case units modelled on established international protocols (UK National Crime Agency, US NIJ guidelines) should systematically address the accumulated backlog using improved forensic and digital techniques.

5. Improve FIR Screening. With 26% of final reports classified as false or civil disputes (~2,73,000 cases), better gatekeeping at the FIR stage through the mandatory preliminary inquiry framework directed in Lalita Kumari v. Government of UP (2013) would meaningfully reduce investigator workload while protecting genuine complainants.

6. Build a National Property Crime Intelligence Database. Stolen vehicles and goods cross state lines; state-level databases are insufficient. A national interoperable property crime database linked to motor vehicle records would enable instant cross-state verification. The NCRB is ideally positioned to develop and maintain such a

system.

11. Conclusion

This analysis of NCRB Table 17A has constructed a diagnostic picture of how India's police system processed over 44 lakh IPC investigations in 2019. What emerges is not a single catastrophic failure but a pattern of structural mismatches — between the volume of cases the system receives and the investigative capacity it has to resolve them; between the type of evidence complex crimes require and the forensic tools available to gather it; and between the gravity of certain offence categories and the resources deployed to investigate them.

India's national 67.2% Charge-Sheeting Rate is not a weak performance by international standards. But averages conceal enormous variation. The 28.5% CSR for property crimes, the 71% of non-prosecution closures citing evidentiary failure, and the more than 20,000 unresolved murder cases at year-end are not statistical anomalies — they represent large-scale, systematic failures of the criminal justice promise. None of them are inevitable. They reflect resource allocation choices, technology investment decisions, training priorities, and institutional design, all of which can be changed.

Perhaps the most important observation is about the data itself. A dataset that tells us not just how many crimes were reported but why 10 lakh cases were closed without prosecution — at the level of individual crime categories — is a diagnostic tool of extraordinary value. The NCRB has built that tool. The question is whether policymakers, police administrators, and researchers will use it with the rigour and seriousness it deserves.

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— End of Report —

All data sourced from National Crime Records Bureau, Ministry of Home Affairs, Government of India (Crime in India 2019)